have acquired any property, movable or immovable, as a result of the commission of an offence triable under this Act. Though the Act doesn't mention the provision for demolition of properties, it has been invoked by the Adityanath government against several gangsters to seize or raze properties they are accused to have acquired illegally.

Indeed, in the past five years of his rule, Adityanath earned the nickname of 'Bulldozer Baba' for the extensive use of bulldozers to free up over 67,000 acres of government land from the clutches of the land mafia.

This stern course of action had widespread public support and Adityanath declared during his assembly polls campaign that bulldozers would be back. According to media reports, the CM mentioned the word 'bulldozer' during rallies at 58 places. The BJP won in all those seats. Adityanath's counterparts in BJP-ruled states such as MP, Gujarat and Assam, have tried to replicate the model in their respective states, where bulldozers have been used to demolish the houses of those accused in riots or vandalism.



ANI

THE BULLDOZER TREATMENT

Some BJP-ruled states have used this machine to punish criminals and those allegedly involved in protests/riots. On paper, these buildings were razed because they flouted building norms or were built on encroached government land

UTTAR PRADESH, JUNE: On June 3 and June 10, violence breaks out after Friday prayers during protests against derogatory remarks on Prophet Muhammed by suspended BJP spokesperson Nupur Sharma. On June

On March 22, when a youth died in Raisen district in Madhya Pradesh after a clash between two communities, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan ordered the demolition of the allegedly illegal houses and shops of the accused persons. The bulldozers came out once again when clashes erupted in Khargone district of the state on Ramnavami. According to reports, 16 houses and 29 shops of alleged stone-pelters were demolished. Chouhan's actions, thought supporters, merited a comparable nickname, and thus was born the moniker 'Bulldozer Mama'.

In Gujarat, civic authorities at Khambhat in Anand district razed seven kiosks and pushcarts, which belonged to some of the persons accused of attacking a religious procession on Ramnavami. In the national capital, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, run by the BJP, carried out a demolition drive to remove "illegal structures" at Jahangirpuri, following a clash between Hindus and Muslims during a procession on Hanuman Jayanti. The drive was stopped by the Supreme Court, which asked the MCD to maintain status quo until further order. On May 22, authorities in Assam's Nagaon district demolished the homes of five families that were allegedly involved in setting fire to a police station the previous day.

In all these instances, the official reason cited for pulling down the structures was either violation of building laws or encroachment on government land. All authorities involved have denied links between the demolition of houses by civic authorities and police finding the owners involved in any crime, protests or agitations. They also assert that due processes were followed, including serving the house owners advance notice. The "victims" say they never received one on time, nor did they ever violate the law. Ironically, in Madhya Pradesh, some of the houses demolished were built under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana.

CAN THE GOVERNMENT RAZE HOUSES?

Legal and civic authorities say that the legality of these demolitions falls in a grey area. Vagueness in building laws and unwillingness of many citizens to strictly follow norms result in violations in most individual and commercial structures. The deviations from due course are so widespread and often so minor that government agencies mostly ignore them. But if they decide to, they can pick holes in most constructions. "In cities, it's not possible to build houses or commercial buildings without getting the drawings passed by civic authorities. However, often during construction, changes from the original plans are made. Unless it's major and rampant, or a specific com-